

Assertiveness Skills

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Assertiveness can be described as obtaining our desired outcomes from others without contravening their rights (Eunson, 2012). Communicating with appropriate assertiveness enables us to be effective in:

- Giving and receiving compliments
- Making requests. E.g. for favours or assistance, initiating and maintaining conversations, etc.
- Standing up for your legitimate rights
- Refusing requests
- Expressing personal opinions, including disagreement
- Expressing justified annoyance, displeasure and anger

Assertiveness techniques

Eunson (2012, p297-300), provides a number of specific techniques we can practice to be more assertive and communicate more effectively.

Say “No”

There are many reasons it may be difficult to say no to someone. For example, there may be a power imbalance where the other person is more senior, or you may find it difficult to tell a colleague ‘no’ if they have put a lot of effort into something. Explaining to someone that you cannot satisfy or fulfil their request can be delicate. It is important to try and avoid being condescending. Rather, speak with a clear, firm voice, politely and without strain. Also, follow up your negative response with an explanation, so that your audience understands why you are responding that way. Often it is useful to offer an alternative.

A good mantra to follow is ‘Come with a solution, not a problem.’

Dismiss/Redirect Conversation

Another technique we can use is the technique of dismiss and redirect, in order to get a conversation back on track. If someone is focussing on something we think is unimportant,

we can explain that (the dismissal), and then suggest what we should be focussing on (the redirection) (Eunson, 2012).

Example: Lin has been asked to prepare a report on the user requirements for an update to the document management system. The conversation might go like this:

Lin: *Could you tell me about any new functionality you would like to see in the document management system?*

User: *There are so many issues, I don't know where to start. We have problems with printing, it is difficult to find documents and management always wants things yesterday.*

Lin: *I acknowledge your broader concerns, but at this time we need to focus just on this aspect of the system [Dismiss]. These broader issues could be raised with management for consideration in the future [Redirect].*

Questioning to Prompt Awareness

Also, by asking certain questions, we can bring a matter to someone's attention. This is a way of challenging their thinking, so we ought to consider how they will feel about being challenged before using this technique.

"Have you noticed that whenever you talk to your subordinates, they are fearful of you? [Questioning to prompt awareness] If you observe their body language next time, you will find that they behave like small children being scolded by their parents" (Eunson, 2012)

Fogging

'Fogging' is a technique whereby we calmly acknowledge criticism. Sometimes this criticism will be justified, other times not. Either way, by acknowledging the criticism rather than becoming defensive, we take the force out of the criticism. This means that "when others then lash out, instead of connecting with something solid, they find it is like punching fog" (Eunson, 2012, p.298)

Example: Lin faces a user who is very angry because his printer keeps failing. The conversation might go like this:

User: *Why can't you tech people ever fix things properly? This problem has happened so many times. I keep calling, someone comes and does something, then the next day the printer fails again.*

Lin: *I am sorry this keeps happening. It would be very frustrating ,and I apologise that we have not been able to fix it for you. [Fogging]*

Forcing a Choice

Sometimes, we may have been asked to complete a task when we have already been assigned other tasks. It may be necessary to clarify what objective should be prioritised.

Example

Lin is currently undertaking a major review of the document management system and is talking to the users about what they want. Each conversation takes time, and at the conclusion she must write a report for management with recommendations. Her boss Kamil then asks her to do an audit of equipment in her area and establish what needs to be replaced. How should she respond? Below is an example of what she might be able to say.

Kamil: *We have an issue with outdated equipment in your area. We need to do a major audit to establish what should be written off and replaced. I would like you to do this and I need it completed by the end of month.*

Lin: *I understand there are numerous issues with the equipment in our area and some of it is no longer working. There are issues with the database of equipment so it will take time to identify everything. I am currently working on the report on the document management system which is taking all my time. Please tell me which task is the most important and I will focus on that one [Forcing a choice]*

Broken Record

Sometimes, our audience may not receive our message clearly the first time. When this happens we can use the ‘broken record’ technique. This involves clearly and calmly repeating (over and over again, if necessary) our message, without getting frustrated or distracted (Eunsons, 2012, p.299).

Ask For Specifics

Sometimes, we may face harsh criticism which isn’t really very helpful. Instead of becoming frustrated or angry, it is more worthwhile to see if we can discern any useful, constructive feedback, by asking for specific explanations. The other person will either be able to provide

that feedback (which can be constructive) or their lack of specific explanations will defuse their criticism.

Example

Lin has just returned from a difficult request from one of the staff, Jim. The staff member was angry because a request to fix his computer had been logged two days earlier but no one had come to see what the problem was. The staff member complained to Lin's boss.

Kamil: *What on earth did you think you were doing, this was unacceptable.*

Lin: *Can you tell me specifically what was unacceptable? [Ask for specifics]*

Workable compromise

When others become frustrated, try to find a way to compromise so that they may be satisfied. This process of compromise is also integral to effective teamwork.

Example: Lin having asked her boss what was unacceptable, the conversation continued.

Kamil: *The delay in getting back to Jim was unacceptable, he should have been a top priority.*

Lin: *Yes, I agree. I did try and contact him earlier but he was not at his desk, and I should have tried again yesterday. I will make sure he is a priority in the future. [Workable compromise]*

Threat

Sometimes, we may feel that it is appropriate to make others aware of the consequences of their actions. However while threats can be useful, this assertiveness technique should be used carefully, as the other party is likely to resent being threatened. It is best to use threats as a last resort and ensure that you are able to carry out any threats you make. Preferably, when using the 'threat' technique, also offer a 'carrot' to go with the 'stick'. This gives the other person positive options (Eunson, 2012, p.300).

Listening Skills

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Listening is one of the most important communication skills for any professional, as it can allow:

- Understanding the full detail of a situation
- Opportunity to learn and develop
- Let others work through and resolve their own issues
- Makes others more likely to listen to us

Listening and Power Dynamics

Listening abilities in communication can vary with power and gender dynamics. For example, high- status individuals are more likely to interrupt low-status people, than vice-versa. Also, previous research (Atwater, 1991) demonstrated that men were more likely to interrupt women, than vice-versa. These tendencies are worth keeping in mind as we audit our listening skills.

Non-verbal Communication as a Listening Technique

Non-verbal cues such as facial expressions and body language are important aspects of both interpreting others' communications. This involves:

- Listening to their words
- Observing their non-verbal behaviour
- Evaluating whether the content of their communication (the words) match the behaviour

Listening Responsiveness

Non-verbal cues can also make our own communications more effective – while listening. We do this by giving the person we are listening to non-verbal feedback, to demonstrate our attentiveness. Following are some good examples of effective 'listening responsiveness' techniques are (Eunson, 2012, p.315):

- Nodding our heads
- An attentive, upright, slightly forward-leaning posture
- Orienting our body towards the speaker
- Using our facial features, including: Raising our eyebrows
Smiling (or frowning)
- Making direct eye contact
- Mirroring the facial expression of the speaker
- Making appropriate “friendly grunts” (“uh-huh”, “mmm-hmm”)

Effective Listening Barriers

In order to listen effectively, we have to engage ourselves with listening to the speaker – even when they may be boring. We can also use clarification questions, as discussed in questioning skills. Eunson (2012, pp.318-319) suggests a number of barriers to effective listening, including:

- Changing the subject
- Not paying attention by daydreaming or becoming distracted
- Focusing on the facts being communicated without paying attention to the thoughts or feelings of the speaker
- Attempting to ‘mind read’ by over-thinking/interpreting the speaker’s words
- Letting our judgement interfere with receiving the message, for example by stereotyping or fixating on issues on which we have strong opinions
- Rehearsing our response when we should be listening

Active Listening Techniques

Active listening is a communication skill using minimal verbal responses to spur the speaker to articulate and clarify their meaning (Eunson, 2012). In many respects this is a two stage process, of listening to the speaker and then seeking feedback from the speaker to ensure that we have understood properly. This process involves (Eunson, 2012, p.319):

- Clarifying the speaker's meaning
 - Checking the accuracy of what the speaker has said
 - Summarising back to the speaker what they have said
 - Acknowledge what the speaker has said, without making any kind of commitment
 - 'Open a door', prompting the speaker to continue
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Questioning Skills

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Being able to seek useful responses with effective questioning techniques is a valuable professional skill. As speakers (or as listeners), we need to know the different types of questions we can ask and match them to the situation and the people we are communicating with.

Eunson (2012) suggests a number of different questioning types, including:

- **Direct probe** – a direct, perhaps blunt question, without the subtlety often involved in seeking information
- **Open** – a question with a broad scope of response – rather than just 'yes' or 'no'. These tend to start with: who; what; when; where; how? These questions allow responders to tell their story
- **Closed** – questions seeking a limited response, most often 'yes' or 'no', to confirm specific information
- **Objective criteria** – questions which focus on the objective facts, to defuse any contentious situations
- **Testing** – when we already know the answer, but are testing the responders knowledge or skills. Softening up – these questions allow us to 'soften up' our audience by building rapport or flattering. Often we will already know the answer to these questions

- **Hypothetical** – ‘what if’ questions allow exploring options without binding the parties involved **Reflective** – a reflective question reflects the other person’s feelings back to them, giving them feedback that these feelings are acknowledged
- **Leading** – more than a closed question, a leading question suggests the response – in this regard it is extremely limited as it only seeks the response we wish to hear.

Using Open and Closed Questions in Information Seeking

It is worthwhile reading through all the different questioning techniques and examples provided by Eunson (2012, p.322-323). It is important to use the right question for the right circumstance. For example, as a leading question suggests the answer, it can be restrictive as we may not have an opportunity to hear the full response people want to give, and they can feel manipulated in some circumstances.

‘Closed’ and ‘open’ questions provide another good example. Questions may exist on a spectrum from open to closed, which is useful for example for information seeking, both for this unit (research and interviews) in seeking information from colleagues, clients and partners in our professional careers.

Open questions are useful when we meet someone for the first time or we are working through an issue for the first time, open questions can help us to break the ice and build rapport. Open questions are particularly useful because their open nature allows for broad and expansive responses, making them very effective. Open questions can help ensure we don’t miss important aspects by becoming too closed too quickly – however they will not be as appropriate when seeking a specific, direct response.

Open questions are particularly useful in the early stages of information gathering, using phrasing which spurs a broad, discursive response: Who? What? When? Where? How?

Closed questions, at the other end of the spectrum, have a limited range of responses, often limited to ‘yes’ and ‘no’ – though they may allow a range of responses, it is a limited range. The key distinction from open questions is that closed questions are less likely to spur a broad

discussion. Closed questions can be useful for establishing facts, getting commitments or choices from people and sometimes they help us to achieve closure or precision. However, keep in mind that closed questions can be a little bit too blunt to help build rapport with others and that when seeking information, moving to closed questions too quickly may result in missing out on important information.

Feedback Skills

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Effective feedback gives the recipient advice, support or constructive criticism. However, when feedback is used or viewed as a punishment, it is not likely to be productive (Eunson, 2012, p.323-324).

Accordingly, it is important that we manage our tone when delivering feedback and try to maintain a positive perspective when receiving feedback.

Effective feedback includes both positive and negative aspects. In order for feedback to be constructive, it ought to be (Eunson, 2012, p.324):

- Fair
- Accurate
- Specific
- Formally structured
- Solution oriented
- Focused on behaviour, not personality

In contrast, when feedback lacks these attributes, it is destructive and not likely to lead to improvement. Effective feedback is assertive and clear, without being aggressive or manipulative (Eunson, 2012, p.327).

The Ideal Ratio of Positive-to-Negative Feedback

In professional (and personal) life, both positive and negative feedback is integral to working productively with others and achieving required outcomes and improvements. Interestingly, research suggests that the ratio of positive-to-negative comments has a significant influence

on productivity and effectiveness (Losada & Heaphy, 2004). According to the research, the highest performing teams experienced a ratio of positive-to-negative comments on average of 5.6:1, while poorly performing teams averaged a ratio of 0.36:1 (Losada & Heaphy, 2004).

This is worthwhile remembering and applying in our professional capacity – in order to fulfill this ‘5:1’ ratio, making a habit of giving our colleagues positive feedback helps to build the positive side of the ratio, so that we are able to provide negative feedback when required without it having a negative effect on productivity and effectiveness.

Intercultural communication skills

There are 4 types of multicultural communication challenges in a workplace

- Direct versus indirect communication.
- Trouble with accents and fluency.
- Different attitudes toward hierarchy and authority.
- Conflicting norms for decision making.

What does it mean exactly to have intercultural communication skills?

It means the communications skills are those required to communicate, or share information, with people from other cultures and social groups, in which you need the following:

- You understand that different cultures have different customs, standards, social mores, and even thought patterns.
- You have the willingness to accept differences and adapt to them

There are several techniques to develop intercultural communication skills, which are given below.

- **After every intercultural communication situation, carefully reflect about its outcomes**
 - Ask yourself questions like the following
 - what behaviors did the other side use that confused me/that I didn’t understand?
 - how did the other side perceive my behavior?

- **Always try to understand the other side's motivations behind every behavior**
 - Ask yourself questions like these
 - what are the beliefs and motivations underlying his or her behavior?
 - in what way does his or her perspective on this issue differ from my own?
- **Question your beliefs and assumptions on a regular basis**
 - See every encounter with somebody from another culture as a learning opportunity.
- **Suspend Judgments**
 - Whether it is 'foolish', 'wrong' or 'stupid', either of these negative labels will prevent you from gaining a real understanding of the other culture.
- **Constantly ask for feedback**
 - Regularly ask other people from the other culture with whom we are interacting about how our behavior came across to them.